"When it comes to development, the Left Front government never considers the 'communal angle'," claims Raju Abraham, the former CPI(M) legislator from neighbouring Ranni, who first made the submission on fast-tracking the Sabarimala airport project in 2019. "The airport will help promote religious tourism, but it will also be a godsend for native-born NRIs. More than the seasonal pilgrims, the airport is going to help NRI Keralites who trace their origins to Pathanamthitta, Kottayam and Idukki district and the tourists going to Idukki." The 63-year-old, who was MLA for five terms, is hopeful that it will boost the economy of his constituency, Ranni, a small township in the foothills which suffered heavily during the 2018 mega floods. The sacred Pampa river had breached the banks and hundreds of shops hugging the embankments were destroyed completely. Some 15 people had also died.

The Sabarimala shrine attracts around 4 million pilgrims annually, mostly from south India. Normally, greenfield airports are given clearance only if the location is at least 150 km from the nearest international airport. The Sabarimala airport will come up on land in the Erumely South and Manimala villages, just 88 km from the Kochi international airport and 110 km from the one in Thiruvananthapuram, but over hill terrain. Overriding the distance norms, the Centre and the civil aviation ministry have given clearance, with Prime Minister Narendra Modi himself expressing happiness over the project in April 2023.

The current project site had been in the news since the late 2000s when it was part of the Harrison estate owned by the R.P. Goenka group, with the state laying claim to it saying it was encroached public land. In 2011, they sold the 2,263-acre Cheruvally estate to K.P. Yohannan, a self-claimed bishop based in the adjoining Thiruvalla district, who has off and on been involved in a series of FEMA (Foreign Exchange Management Act) cases. He, in turn, offered the land to the then Congress-led United Democratic Front (UDF) regime to set up the Sabarimala airport in 2012. An MoU to buy the land was signed in 2020 at the fag end of Pinarayi's first term.

AIRPORT AT A GLANCE

2,570 ACRES
2,263.2 acres from Cheruvally estate and **307** acres outside it

₹260 CRORE
Cost of the land

₹3,900 CRORE
Total project cost

2030
Expected completion year

3,500 METRES
Runway length with 45-metre and 7.5-metre shoulders on either side

1.69 MILLION
Estimated no. of passengers annually

₹237 CRORE
Estimated annual revenue from airport

CLEARANCES
Received from defence, civil aviation and environment ministries; awaited from MHA

WITH THE LOK SABHA POLLS LOOMING, BOTH PINARAYI AND THE PM WILL BE VYING TO TAKE CREDIT FOR THE PROJECT

The new airport in Erumely has many enthusiasts. "We want an airport near our home and we don't care who provides it. The Kochi airport was a big relief, but the Sabarimala airport will be much closer to home," says K.G. Sajeev, who lives in Australia. His home in Elanthoor is less than 30 km from the airport site. NRI businessman Varghese Madassery agrees. "Kerala is changing. People want a developed state without banners and party colours and they don't care which party provides it. If you do the work, you'll get the support," he points out. This sentiment among the NRIs and pilgrims is exactly what both Modi and Pinarayi are trying to tap into. The Lok Sabha election is coming up, and both sides will be vying to take credit for the project. Indeed, a joke doing the rounds is that Sabarimala is the only issue where Modi and Pinarayi see eye to eye. State finance minister K.N. Balagopal has set aside Rs 1.88 crore in the budget for the land mapping survey, a signal that the new airport is on the priority list.

Meanwhile, little thought has gone into whether the eco-sensitive Sabarimala temple core area—a tropical forest—can handle the number of pilgrims being projected. The Travancore Devaswom Board that manages the temple put the figures for the recently concluded *mandalam* season at around 3 million. That was some 250,000 less than 2022, but, even then, the crowds from the Pampa basin to the temple *sannidhanam* became unmanageable, with reports of the 5 km uphill trek taking 24 hours and more because of the rush. The situation at the base camps at Nilackal and Pampa was worse. The new airport, to be built on a PPP model, though, seems to have the blessings of everyone around. The thoughts of bachelor god Ayyappan on the matter are, of course, unknown. ■